

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Quality Objectives Worksheet

Turn a vague ambition like "improve quality" into measurable objectives with a baseline, a target, a measure and an owner.

Purpose

"Improve quality" is not an objective — it cannot be planned, funded or judged. This worksheet converts strategic intent into specific, measurable quality objectives, each with a baseline (where you are now), a target (where you want to be), a measure (how you will know), an owner and a timeframe. It forces the honesty of naming a current number, and it makes success or failure visible rather than a matter of opinion.

When to use it

- Immediately after agreeing a QA strategy, to make its objectives operational.
- At the start of a quarter or planning cycle, to set what quality will improve and by how much.
- When you need to demonstrate impact — a baseline captured now is what lets you prove progress later.
- In goal-setting conversations, to connect individual and team goals to quality outcomes.

Instructions

For each objective, write an outcome (not an activity — "reduce escaped defects", not "write more tests"), then fill the columns. The baseline is the hardest and most important column: if you cannot state today's number, capturing it becomes the first task. Choose measures you can actually collect without heroics. Set targets that are ambitious but credible. Assign a single owner. Prefer a small number of objectives that matter over a long list that dilutes focus — three to five is usually right.

Worked example

Quality objectives for Northstar Digital's first two quarters, derived from its strategy.

Objective (outcome)	Measure	Baseline	Target	Owner	By when
Reduce escaped defects reaching production	Production defects per release attributable to escaped issues	Not currently tracked (establish baseline in month 1)	Baseline, then 30% reduction over two quarters	Head of QA	End Q2

Objective (outcome)	Measure	Baseline	Target	Owner	By when
Shorten the release regression bottleneck	Elapsed time for the pre-release test pass on critical paths	~5 days manual	Under 1 day for critical paths via risk-based + automated checks	Head of QA + squad leads	End Q2
Make automation trustworthy	Flaky-test rate in the critical-journey suite	~25% flaky (full suite)	Under 5% flaky in a smaller, curated critical-journey suite	Automation engineer	End Q1
Improve defect prioritisation	Proportion of defects with correctly applied severity and priority (sampled)	Loose / inconsistent	90% correctly triaged against agreed definitions	Head of QA	End Q1
Make QA value visible to execs	A monthly report on escaped defects and change failure rate exists and is used	No outcome metrics reported	Report live and referenced in release decisions	Head of QA	End Q1

Blank reusable version

Objective (outcome)	Measure	Baseline	Target	Owner	By when

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Writing activities dressed up as objectives ("run more automated tests") instead of the outcome you actually want. Setting a target with no baseline, so you can never prove you moved. Choosing vanity measures that go up without anything real improving — test-case counts are the classic. Setting too many objectives, so focus dissolves. And picking measures that are easy to game: if hitting the number can be achieved without the underlying quality improving, choose a better number.

How to interpret the results

- A "baseline unknown" is not a failure — it is your first objective. Capturing the number is real progress, and doing so often changes the conversation on its own.
- If you cannot name a measure for an objective, it is probably an aspiration rather than an objective. Reword it or drop it.
- Track trend, not just endpoint. An objective moving in the right direction is on course even before it hits target; one that is flat needs intervention now, not at the deadline.
- If a target is hit but the underlying problem persists, your measure was gameable. Replace it.
- Review objectives openly with the team. Ones that are consistently missed usually signal an unrealistic target, a blocked dependency or the wrong owner — all worth surfacing early.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

The single most valuable thing you can do in your first month is capture baselines — even rough ones. Numbers you record now are what let you say, a quarter later, "escaped defects are down 30% and the regression bottleneck is gone." Without a baseline, real improvement is indistinguishable from luck, and neither you nor your team gets the credit you have earned.